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1. Cas Lek Cesk. 2007;146(7):573-7.

[Milestones of cardiovascular therapy. IV. Reserpine].

[Article in Czech]

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Reserpine, the purified alkaloid of *Rauwolfia serpentina*, was the first potent drug widely used in the long-term treatment of hypertension. *Rauwolfia serpentina* is a tropical woody plant of the Apocyanaceae family indigenous to Asia, South America and Africa. Extracts of its different parts and of plants resembling to *rauwolfia* were used in Hindu medicine for snakebite, insomnia, insanity and many other diseases and complaints. In Europe, Georg Eberhard Rumpf first reported about *rauwolfia* in his *Herbarium amboinense*, 1755. The first modern paper about therapeutic applications of the whole root of *rauwolfia* was published in 1931 in the *Indian Medical Journal* by Sen and Bose, and many papers dealing with botanics, chemistry and pharmacology then appeared in Indian and European periodicals. In 1949, Vakil published the first report of the antihypertensive effect of *rauwolfia* in the *British Heart Journal*. In the Ciba laboratories in Basel, Switzerland, Mueller, Schlittler and Bein analysed various *rauwolfia* alkaloids and published in 1952 the first complete report about their chemistry and pharmacology. In the same year, reserpine was introduced under the name *Serpasil* in the treatment of hypertension, tachycardia and thyrotoxicosis. The combination of reserpine, dihydroergocristine and a diuretic is still on the market (*Brinerdin*, *Crystepin*). In psychiatry, reserpine was prescribed as a tranquilizing agent until modern synthetic antidepressant and antipsychotic drugs were introduced. The author also briefly summarizes the chemistry, pharmacology and clinical use of reserpine.

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